Nursing Essentials

Priority: Call for help early. Support maternal circulation and fetal oxygenation while the team addresses the cause.

FOCUS 1

Relieve pressure

- **Clue:** sudden prolonged deceleration / bradycardia, especially after membrane rupture; a cord may be seen or palpated.
- **Act:** activate emergency assistance; relieve pressure from the presenting part using the prescribed maneuver and positioning.
- **Prepare:** stop oxytocin per protocol and prepare for urgent birth. Avoid unnecessary cord handling or attempting replacement.

FOCUS 2

Free shoulders

- **Clue:** the head delivers but the shoulders do not; the head may retract against the perineum.
- **Act:** call the team, note the time, and assist with McRoberts positioning and suprapubic pressure as directed.
- **Avoid:** fundal pressure and excessive traction. Prepare for neonatal support and maternal bleeding assessment.

FOCUS 3

Resuscitate

- **Clues:** acute fetal deterioration, pain, loss of station, vaginal bleeding, or maternal shock; pain may be masked.
- **Act:** emergency escalation, resuscitative support, and rapid preparation for operative management.
- **Think broadly:** a reassuring amount of visible bleeding does not exclude major internal blood loss.

Other time-critical patterns

Make it stick: Know the difference: suprapubic pressure may help shoulder dystocia; fundal pressure can worsen the impaction.

Focus	What to know	Nursing application
Vasa previa	bleeding after rupture plus fetal deterioration can indicate fetal blood loss even when maternal vital signs seem stable.	Prepare urgent birth
Amniotic fluid embolism	sudden hypoxemia, cardiovascular collapse, and coagulopathy require immediate multidisciplinary resuscitation.	Activate resuscitation
Stay coordinated	communicate the change, interventions, response, and time course; document without delaying care.	Use clear handoffs

RED FLAGS · ESCALATE PROMPTLY

Cord prolapse, acute fetal deterioration, suspected rupture, maternal collapse, or bleeding with fetal compromise requires emergency team activation.